a risk of making yourself feel uncomfortable and of thinking too much about your technique. I've always felt that I've batted best when my mind has been at the bowler's end of the pitch, not at my end. In fact, for both batsmen and bowlers, I've always believed that cricket is played best when your mind is at the opposite end and that problems occur when your mind is stuck at your own end.

For example, if a bowler is thinking too much about bowling no-balls, he's not going to be able to bowl what he wants to bowl. Instead, his mind should be at the batsman's end, focusing on where he's going to pitch the ball, which way he's going to swing it and so on. As a batsman, if I'm not consciously worrying about my footwork or my backlift or my wrist-work, then I know that I'm in the right space, because my mind needs to be at the opposite end, figuring out what the bowler is trying to do. There's no time to think about both ends at the same time. So in general it always seemed to me that if I was comfortable with my gear, it would allow my mind to be at the opposite end and I had a better chance of playing well.

India in England, the Test series, July–September 2002

I have always enjoyed playing in England, but on the 2002 tour it took the team a little time to adjust to the conditions. The first of the four Tests, at Lord's, started on 25 July 2002 and England won pretty convincingly, with Hussain making his highest score for five years and Michael Vaughan also contributing a century. For India, the high point was my friend Ajit Agarkar's second-innings hundred, and I was delighted to see his name go up on the famous honours board in the dressing room.

We knew we needed to be more competitive in the next Test at Trent Bridge ten days later if we were to stay alive in the four-match series. Once again England posted a huge score, with Vaughan again in good form, and we were faced with batting out the last day to survive. The pitch was assisting the bowlers and quite a few balls were taking off from a good length, while some were keeping low. In difficult circumstances, Rahul and I put together an important partnership. There were occasions when we were beaten by balls which had either taken off or kept low and all we did was smile. We chatted at the end of every over